INFORMATION PROCESSING

The consumer's belief in the advertisement is affected by how the consumer processes the information presented in it. There are eight stages of information processing involved in the comprehension of advertisements. The belief component of the consumer's attitude toward the product can be formed or modified at any stage. The first stage is exposure: the consumer must have the opportunity to perceive the advertisement. The second stage is attention: the consumer may pay attention to part or all of an advertisement. The third stage is comprehension: the consumer must understand the information in the ad. The fourth stage is evaluation: the consumer assesses the information presented in the ad. The fifth stage is encoding: the consumer encodes, or saves, the advertised information in long-term memory. Later, the sixth stage, retrieval, in which the consumer retrieves the encoded information, can occur. The seventh stage is decision: the consumer decides to buy (or not buy) the advertised product.

MISCOMPREHENSION

The final stage is the action of buying the product. Advertisers may persuade consumers to buy their product by intentionally inducing miscomprehension. The basis of the miscomprehension is the tendency for people to encode inferences, or interpretations, of stated advertising claims. Therefore, the consumer later remembers inferences made, but not explicitly stated, about a product. At no point is the advertiser presenting false information, but the advertisement is structured in a way that induces the consumer to draw a specific inference. An advertisement might use hedge words such as "may" or "could." For example, pain reliever Brand A "may help" prevent heart attacks.

Other advertisements contain elliptical comparatives. In an elliptical comparison, the standard that something is being compared to is intentionally left out. The consumer naturally completes the comparison with the most logical standard. However, the true standard might not be the most logical. For example, cereal Brand A "gives you more." More what? A logical standard might be "more vitamins." The true standard might be "more heartburn." An advertisement might imply causation when in actuality the relationship is correlational. Juxtaposing two imperative statements implies that the first statement leads to, or causes, the next statement: Buy Brand A tires. Drive safely.